WATCH

ANNIVERSARY

THE ORIGINAL SPIN

Breguet invented the tourbillon 225 years ago and has spent every decade since, refining it. Its anniversary quartet proves the old house still knows how to make a cage worth watching.

By Dhiram Shah

There are watch brands that use the word tourbillon the way mediocre restaurants use truffle oil: liberally, noisily and usually in the hope that no one asks too many questions. Then there is Breguet, which does not need to raise its voice because it wrote the opening chapter. Abraham-Louis Breguet patented the tourbillon in 1801, at a time when the idea was not about flexing on Instagram or winning auction-room applause, but about solving a stubbornly elegant problem: gravity. That matters, because it explains why Breguet's relationship with the complication still feels different from everyone else's. This is not borrowed mythology; it is family silver. The best part of the new 225th-anniversary releases is that they do not drown in reverence. They are historically informed without becoming museum pieces, and that is harder than it sounds. Of the four launches, two feel especially persuasive. One is the sort of watch that will have serious collectors quietly reaching for a loupe and then their cheque books. The other is a reminder that Breguet, when it is really in form, can make high watchmaking feel faintly supernatural. Together, they make a compelling case that the maison's future lies not in being louder, larger or more "luxury" in the modern sense, but in being more unapologetically Breguet.

Classique Tourbillon 7357: The connoisseur's comeback kid

If the 7357 had a personality, it would be the impeccably dressed guest at a black-tie dinner who turns out to be the smartest person in the room and never once mentions it. This, to my mind, is the standout of the quartet. It revives the spirit of the 1989 ref. 3350, the modern-era Breguet tourbillon that collectors still speak about with a certain misty-eyed affection, but it does so without the laziness of a nostalgia act. At 35mm, it is gloriously unbothered by contemporary machismo; in a market that keeps mistaking diameter for importance, that alone feels radical. The new calibre 187B, evolved from the historic movement lineage yet significantly reworked, gives the watch real substance beneath the polish, with improved antimagnetic credentials, a longer power reserve and a more resolved aesthetic architecture. More importantly, the 7357 looks right. The guilloché gold dial, Breguet numerals and that beautifully judged tourbillon opening make it feel like a house classic that has remembered to freshen up before leaving the house. I especially like that Breguet has made this one regular production rather than a blink-and-you'll-miss-it bauble for the usual VIP circus. That gives the watch confidence. It is not begging to be called rare; it is simply secure in the knowledge that it is good.